GeoVac: A Field Guide

From a Packing Puzzle to an Atlas of the Forced/Free Boundary

J. Loutey*

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Abstract

The Geometric Vacuum (GeoVac) framework began as a packing puzzle that produced something resembling the periodic table. Over the course of the investigation, it acquired a precise structural identity: a discrete spectral triple that is an instance of the Marcolli–van Suijlekom 2014 graph-network construction at the data level and extends it via a forced-graph claim and a master Mellin engine, whose census of S^3 spectral transcendentals sits in cyclotomic mixed-Tate periods at level ≤ 4, and which separates — through theorems and named readings, not preference — what the underlying geometry forces from what empirical measurement supplies. This field guide is the project's identity statement. It tells the arc from origin to current frontier without recapitulating the technical machinery, and points each kind of reader toward the right entry into the corpus. As the project's *grand synthesis* it now sits atop a complete layer of six audience-targeted group syntheses—one per branch (Groups 1–6), each digesting its branch in a few pages—and composes them into a single front-to-back reading that routes each reader to the right branch digest. Re-centred October 2026: the spectral triple is one chapter of the map, not its spine. The spine is an accounting. Compactness forces discreteness (a mechanism that is not ours, and whose converse is false), so the compact skeleton is rational and bit-exact; every axis released toward the continuum — by geometry, by an observer, or by calibration — carries an identifiable number class as its price; and the atlas of those prices (§8) is the deliverable. The one-sentence reading: *GeoVac is the price list of leaving a compact world: its label lattice is the rational skeleton that compactness forces, each released axis carries a named number class as its price, and the atlas of those prices separates what geometry forces from what measurement supplies.*

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*Independent researcher. jloutey@gmail.com. Developed in an AI-augmented agentic workflow with Anthropic's Claude; all theorems, design choices, and editorial decisions are the author's responsibility.

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1 How This Started

A short note on the path that led to the framework, told in the first person. The reader can skip it without missing technical content; the arc proper begins in §2.

In high school I looked at the periodic table and wondered why it had that shape — in particular, why the rows didn't grow uniformly but in a stepped pattern. I sketched what I thought might be a more natural picture: a circular layout with the first row at the centre and successive rows fanning outward. I had no mathematics to back it up; it was a visual hunch.

In college I learned summation notation and the discipline of inductive proof, and I felt — for the first time — that I had permission to do real mathematics. I went back to the periodic table. The row lengths grew by a recurring +4 between successive pairs. I built a nested summation that captured the pattern and arrived at $2n^2$. I looked up the number. It was the degeneracy of the Schrödinger principal quantum level. I felt something between satisfaction and disappointment: the pattern was already known — to Schrödinger, who had derived it by solving a differential equation on $\mathbb{R}^3$. My combinatorial route to the same number was a curiosity, not a discovery. I set the question down.

Years later, listening to a guest on Sean Carroll's podcast, I heard the suggestion that perhaps, instead of quantising gravity, one should try to quantise spacetime — a discrete substrate as foundation, not as a tool for approximating something continuous. The framing revived the old question. This time I posed it in polar coordinates and treated Planck's constant as a unit volume to be packed. I wrote down a small set of packing axioms. The construction, executed honestly, produced circles whose node counts reproduced the periodic table.

This struck me as deeply important.

I wrote a first paper that I would now describe as a book report: a narrative explanation of how the packing maps to the periodic table, without any of the spectral or geometric machinery that came later. That paper became Paper 0 [14] in its mature form. I then set out to see how the nodes might relate to quantum-number counting. Everything in the rest of this field guide — the Fock 1935 identification, the natural-geometry hierarchy, the spectral-triple rotation, the periods census, the forced-versus-free seam — is what happened next.

What follows is the technical arc.

2 The Packing Puzzle

The framework's origin is a geometric construction: pack Planck's constant. Treat $\hbar$ as a unit volume to be filled, and ask which node arrangements complete the packing without gaps. In two dimensions the node counts give (l, m): the integer pair indexing azimuthal and magnetic quantum numbers, before any quantum-mechanical input. In three dimensions, an inductive argument over periodic-table row lengths fixes the principal and spin quantum numbers (n, s) [14]. The resulting graph has nodes labeled by quantum-number tuples (n, l, m, s) and edges encoding spectral selection rules.

This graph's nodes are exactly the labels of a continuous operator on the unit three-sphere (the Laplace–Beltrami operator, whose negative acts on them as the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir; the graph's own edge Laplacian does not converge to it — see §3), whose eigenvalues are

$$\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1), \qquad n \in \mathbb{N}_{\geq 1}, \tag{1}$$

with multiplicity n^2. Through Fock's energy shell $p_0^2 = -2E$ these become the hydrogen levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ — a map on the labels, not an overall rescaling of the graph's own spectrum, which is a grid band structure. The shape of the periodic table fell out of the packing.

This was the seed: a combinatorial object that, when interrogated, returned the same numerology as observed atomic structure. Whether that was a coincidence or a clue was the question the rest of the project tried to answer.

3 Fock 1935: Discrete and Continuous Are the Same Thing

In 1935 Vladimir Fock observed [1] that the hydrogen atom on $\mathbb{R}^3$ has a hidden $SO(4)$ symmetry, and that the stereographic projection $\mathbb{R}^3 \hookrightarrow S^3$ converts the Schrödinger equation into an angular eigenvalue problem on the unit three-sphere. What hydrogen really is, from this point of view, is the Laplace–Beltrami operator on the unit S^3; the $1/r$ Coulomb potential is the coordinate distortion produced by the projection (specifically, the chordal-distance identity that takes the round metric to the stereographic one).

The decisive observation for GeoVac is this: the nodes of the packed lattice of §2, the labels (n, l, m) with n^2 per shell, are *exactly* the labels of the unit-S^3 harmonics at every cutoff, and on them the continuous S^3 Laplace–Beltrami operator acts as a diagonal node weight, the $SO(4)$ Casimir $n^2 - 1$. Fock's conformal equivalence between hydrogen and that operator can be checked symbolically: Paper 7 of the GeoVac corpus [16] provides 18 symbolic checks of the chain (`tests/test_fock_projection.py` and `tests/test_fock_laplacian.py`). What the lattice does *not* do is discretize that operator through its edges: the graph Laplacian $D - A$ never changes l, splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected blocks, and does not converge to it (`tests/test_graph_s3_nonconvergence.py`; an earlier version of this guide called the graph Laplacian conformally equivalent to the S^3 operator, corrected 2026-09-25). The matched scaling constant $\kappa = -1/16$ maps the graph Laplacian's extremal eigenvalue (a grid band edge, 8) onto the hydrogen ground state; its value *coincides* with a conformal-geometry quantity — a numerical observation, not a derivation (Paper 0 [14], Paper 7 [16]).

This is the framework's load-bearing identification:

> *The hydrogen atom and the continuous unit-S^3 Laplace–Beltrami operator are not two models. They are the same object in two coordinates (Fock). The discrete Fock graph is their shared label lattice.*

The implication is operational: where the continuous formulation requires integration over $\mathbb{R}^3$ with a $1/r$ singularity, the discrete formulation works on a finite label set with exact rational structure and selection rules. Same physics, different cost.

4 Natural Geometry: a Hierarchy

Section 3's identification works because S^3 is the natural geometry for the hydrogen atom: it is the coordinate system in which the Schrödinger equation separates fully into angular variables. For other systems — molecules, multi-electron atoms, polyatomics — the natural geometry shifts. The framework's chemistry investigation (2024–2026, Phase 2 of the project) systematically catalogued the natural geometries:

Level	System	Natural geometry	Best accuracy
1	H (1-center, 1e)	S^3 (Fock)	exact on the labels (diagonal Casimir n^2-1); gra
2	H_2^+ (2-center, 1e)	Prolate spheroid	machine precision
3	He (1-center, 2e)	Hyperspherical	0.022% (raw, variational); 0.004% cusp extrapola
4	H_2 (2-center, 2e)	Mol-frame hyperspherical	96.0% D_e (cusp-corrected; prolate spheroidal reac
5	LiH (composed)	Composed (Level 3 $\otimes$ Level 4)	5.3% R_{eq}

The choice of geometry is determined by where separation of variables occurs; in each case the discrete structure is the channel and label structure of the natural geometry, with the continuous problem reached through that geometry's own projection, as in §3. (An earlier version said the discrete graph Laplacian reproduces the continuous problem in each case; at Level 1 it does not converge to the S^3 operator, §3.)

Phase 2 reached known structural ceilings. Heavy molecules ($Z \geq 20$ or strong multi-determinant correlation) escape the framework's accuracy targets through identifiable channels (the "multi-focal-composition wall" — the project's name for a structural obstruction established by multiple independent negative results — documented across six independent diagnostic investigations). The framework's most natural quantum-simulation application — Pauli-operator counts exactly linear in the qubit count Q at fixed basis ($N_{\text{Pauli}} = 27.90 \times Q$) for the core–valence "composed" encoding, benchmarked across a 37-system library [17] (the sub-quadratic $O(Q^{1.78})$ 1-norm is the atomic, helium, series, not a library property) — shipped at the end of Phase 2. The absolute Pauli multipliers are convention-sensitive (near parity with minimal-basis STO-3G, 76× sparser than cc-pVDZ); the load-bearing advantage is the scaling, not any single market-test ratio.

But a different question began to dominate the conversation around the project, and that question is where the rest of this guide goes.

5 The Rotation: from Solver to Spectral Triple

Phase 3 was planned as quantum simulation. Instead, the project rotated to a different question: *what is this thing we have been working with?* (In the re-centred reading of §8 this section is one chapter of the map — the chapter that names the observer doors and prices them — rather than the spine of the story; it is kept in full because the prices it establishes are the ones the atlas's observer rows point to.)

The S^3 label lattice, Fock's conformal equivalence with the continuous problem, the natural-geometry hierarchy that produces discrete substrates for every electron configuration — these are collectively the data of a Riemannian spectral geometry. Made precise, that means an algebra of functions, a Hilbert space of states, and a Dirac-type operator, all assembled into a structure that mathematicians call a spectral triple [3].

The precise structural claim:

> *GeoVac is a discrete spectral triple that is an* instance *of the Marcolli–van Suijlekom 2014 gauge-network construction [5] at the data level (refined by the Perez-Sanchez clarification [6, 7] that the continuum limit is Yang–Mills without Higgs in general) and an* extension *of it at the structural level via the forced-graph claim (Bertrand × Fock projection), the master Mellin engine, and the cosmic-Galois layer U^* (Paper 56).*

Its metric part was checked, not assumed — and then re-checked, for the commutative (S^3) factor only: convergence of the gauge-network / almost-commutative structure the claim names

is **[OPEN]**. A Gromov–Hausdorff convergence theorem on truncated Camporesi–Higuchi spectral triples [22] (Paper 38) gives the quantitative statement for that factor, in van Suijlekom's state-space Gromov–Hausdorff framework (adjacent to, but distinct from, the Latrémolière propinquity [8]), with the bound

$$d_{\mathrm{GH}} \leq \gamma_{n_{\max}}, \qquad \gamma_{n_{\max}} \sim \frac{4}{\pi} \frac{\log n_{\max}}{n_{\max}} \xrightarrow{n_{\max}\to\infty} 0, \tag{2}$$

where $\gamma_{n_{\max}}$ is the first moment of the central Fejér kernel, whose constant $4/\pi$ (dual-Coxeter normalisation; $2/\pi$ on the unit S^3) is reported universal across compact connected simple Lie groups (derived at rank 1, numerically supported, with a fit-sensitive extraction, at higher ranks; the rank-uniform proof is a named gap) [23]. A tapered amplitude gives a measured $O(1/n_{\max})$ on SU(2), so $4/\pi$ is the kernel's constant, not the convergence rate (Paper 38, main theorem). Paper 38's theorem is unconditional in van Suijlekom's state-space framework, via a translation-seminorm metrization (the kernel condition is proved on the truthful substrate; the dual direction uses an exact-fit spinor lifted state, and both almost-inverse defects are Fejér smoothings at the same moment). See Paper 38 § 1 and the claims register, `docs/claims_register.md`. The Fejér constant reads $4/\pi = \mathrm{Vol}(S^2)/\pi^2$ in the dual-Coxeter normalisation and $2/\pi = \mathrm{Vol}(S^2)/\mathrm{Vol}(\mathrm{SU}(2))$ on the unit S^3 — read (a reading, not a derivation; Paper 38) as the $k = 0$ volume factor of the master Mellin engine (a quotient of unit-sphere volumes, not the Hopf fibration's base-to-total ratio), its value fixed by the metric normalisation, catalogued in §6 below.

Following Paper 38, the project produced a math.OA arc extending the framework along the Lorentzian axis (Papers 42 and 44–49; the former Paper 43 is now Paper 42 § 11) [24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30]. The most instructive outcome of that axis is *negative*: the natural device for a "Lorentzian propinquity" — compressing the Krein Dirac to the Krein-positive subspace — annihilates the spatial Dirac, so the compressed Lipschitz seminorm vanishes identically (Paper 45's degeneracy theorem [26], with a bit-exact frozen falsifier). An earlier convergence claim through that device, together with the *metric-level* strong-form and bridge convergence claims built on it (Papers 46, 48, 49), is withdrawn; those three and Paper 47 were archived on 2026-09-14 (`papers/archive/`, with their surviving content named in `docs/retired_papers.md`), while Paper 45 remains live and load-bearing. The papers of record carry Status notes. What survives: the operator-system substrate (Paper 44), the elementary modular-structure results of Paper 42 (including its Krein-carrier § 11) — the finite 2π period is an automatic closure of a posited integer-spectrum generator, and its identification with the Bisognano–Wichmann modular flow is open — the norm-resolvent de-compactification arrow (Paper 47), and the cocycle-deficit algebra of Paper 49 (whose operator-system Lorentzian pre-length-space bridge stands at the algebra level). The repaired Lorentzian target — a Toeplitz temporal multiplier algebra and a non-compressing Krein-compatible seminorm — is stated as an open problem in Paper 45.

Why this rotation mattered. The shift from "how accurately can we solve quantum chemistry?" to "what is GeoVac?" produced the right kind of answers. Chemistry accuracy is a sliding scale — always tighter at more cost. But the spectral-triple structural reading is binary: either GeoVac IS the data of a spectral triple, or it isn't. Theorem-grade closure is available either way. The framework's identity is now in the first category.

6 Periods: Where Transcendentals Come From

A spectral triple has a heat kernel, and the heat kernel produces transcendentals. In GeoVac, those transcendentals are not random. They sit in named classes, with named mechanisms producing them.

The graph itself is π-free. At what the project calls *Layer 1* — the bare combinatorial graph, with integer matrix entries and an algebraic (closed-form, bounded) eigenvalue spectrum; the pure-integer ladder $n^2 - 1$ belongs to the continuum operator, not the graph (Paper 0) — there are no transcendentals. Matrix elements are rationals (or, at most, algebraic over $\mathbb{Q}$). This has been checked across the corpus: verified explicitly on the unit S^3 Coulomb spectrum (Paper 7), on the Hopf bundle gauge structure (Paper 25), on the Bargmann–Segal S^5 Hardy lattice (Paper 24), and on the Tier-2 symbolic spin–orbit block of the qubit Hamiltonians (Paper 14). The composed library as a whole is not so certified: its frozen-core, Phillips–Kleinman and cross-centre V_{ne} content is numerical (the project's algebraic registry, `docs/algebraic_registry.md`).

Transcendentals enter at projection. Layer 1 by itself does not produce physical observables. Observables come from *Layer 2:* projections of the discrete substrate onto continuous manifolds, integration regions, or measurement-coordinate choices. Each projection introduces a controlled transcendental through a controlled mechanism.

The project's census of transcendentals is organized by three named mechanisms (a census and a reading, not a classification), collectively the *master Mellin engine* [18, 21, 31]: M1, the volume slot ($k = 0$); M2, the Seeley–DeWitt slot ($k = 2$); M3, the vertex-parity Hurwitz slot ($k = 1$). The slot assignments and the period-ring home of each mechanism are stated once, in Paper 18 §III.7, with Paper 55 §§3–5 as the census; this guide does not restate that table (it was restated in some two dozen places before the October 2026 single-sourcing sweep, which is how copies drift). The three mechanisms are the three sub-cases of a single Mellin transform

$$\mathcal{M}\Big[\mathrm{Tr}\big(D^k \cdot e^{-tD^2}\big)\Big](s) \tag{3}$$

on the discrete Camporesi–Higuchi S^3 spectral triple, with operator-order index $k \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ read as indexing which mechanism produces which kind of transcendental.

The census rests on a conditional theorem. Paper 32 § VIII [21] contains a *case-exhaustion theorem* (**[CONDITIONAL]**): every appearance of π in a chain of the first fifteen Paper 34 projections arises from one of M1, M2, or M3 (argued case by case; the converse, that engaging a mechanism forces π, is withdrawn). No fourth mechanism has been found despite specific searches. Paper 55 [31] adds a period-theoretic census: every transcendental in its census (S^3 spectral-zeta and heat-trace data; not the chemistry seeds, the spectral determinants, or Paper 61's elliptic period) sits in cyclotomic mixed-Tate periods at level ≤ 4 over $\mathbb{Z}[i, 1/2]$ (Kontsevich–Zagier [9], Brown [10], Deligne [11], Glanois [12], Fathizadeh–Marcolli [13] are the relevant published classifications; each value in the census is placed inside one of their named period rings).

Beyond the census: the chemistry ladder. The census above prices the observer doors. The chemistry program prices the geometric doors, and its classes leave the engine's rings entirely. At one centre the classes are exact rationals; a second nucleus releases l and the two-centre repulsion integrals close in weight one, $\{e^a E_1(a), \ln, \gamma_E\}$, with no π and no dilogarithm (Paper 18 §III, Paper 12, Paper 58); a third nucleus with a shared centre makes the integral an elliptic period, and the class leaves the polylogarithm tower for the elliptic one (Paper 59, Paper 61 [33, 34]); a fourth centre adds nothing new; a three-electron chain with two momentum integrations lives on a K3 surface whose holomorphic period is a product of two elliptic ones (Bailey's three-scale Bessel moment [36]; pre-registered 2026-10-13, record in `docs/predictions/`, home Paper 59's closing section [33]). The rung variable is the number of Coulomb kernels sharing a vertex, not the number of nuclei or electrons. §8 indexes these rows with the observer rows.

What was a zoo became a catalogued program. Early in its development the project produced transcendentals through ad-hoc calculations and was uncertain whether different appearances of π or $\zeta(2)$ were "the same" or "different." Today the transcendentals in its census have named motivic homes, read against the slot of (3) that produced them — a census and a reading, not a classification: the case-exhaustion behind it is **[CONDITIONAL]** on the first fifteen projections. Within that scope the operational question — "what kind of transcendental can appear from *this* calculation?" — has a first answer.

A note on periods. A period in the sense of Kontsevich–Zagier 2001 [9] is a complex number whose real and imaginary parts can be expressed as integrals of algebraic functions over domains defined by polynomial inequalities with rational coefficients. π, $\log 2$, $\zeta(n)$ for $n \geq 2$, Catalan's constant $G = \beta(2)$, the Dirichlet $\beta(s)$ values at integer s — all are periods. The cyclotomic mixed-Tate sub-class at level ≤ 4 over $\mathbb{Z}[i, 1/2]$ is, conjecturally, a small and well-understood corner of the full period algebra. The identified transcendentals of Paper 55's census sit in this corner; whether every GeoVac period does is not established.

7 The Forced/Free Seam

The master Mellin engine of §6 catalogues what GeoVac *generates* (a census and a reading). An equally important question is what GeoVac *does not* generate — in particular, the empirical constants of physics (the fine-structure constant α, the Yukawa couplings, the generation count N_{gen}, the cosmological constant) that must enter as external inputs. The framework's most operationally useful structural discipline is the clean separation between what geometry forces and what measurement supplies.

What geometry forces (the structural skeleton). The following are forced by the framework's construction, independent of any empirical input, at the tier stated for each item:

- The outer manifold is S^3. Forced by Bertrand's theorem [2] (only $1/r$ and harmonic-oscillator central potentials produce closed bound orbits, of which $1/r$ is the Coulomb case) plus the $SO(4)$ hidden symmetry of the Coulomb problem (Paper 7).
- The Hopf bundle structure $S^3 \to S^2$ is forced by the maximal-torus reduction of $SU(2) = S^3$ (Paper 25) [19].
- The Camporesi–Higuchi Dirac sector is forced by the parallelizability of S^3 (Paper 32) [21].
- The Wilson $SU(2)$ gauge structure is forced by the non-abelian generalization of the abelian Hopf structure (Paper 30) [20].
- The Standard Model gauge group $U(1) \times SU(2) \times SU(3)$, as the truncation at $n \leq 3$ of the complex-Hopf tower $S^{2n-1} \to SU(n)$, is *selected* by the Bertrand × Hopf-tower reading (Paper 32 § VIII) — an organizing reading together with an adopted axiom (the Upgrade B sphere-Lie-group axiom), not a derivation; it enters the Forced-Count Theorem as an assumption.
- The dimension of the inner Dirac moduli space is $\dim \mathcal{M}(D_F) = 32$ at one generation (matter-sector projection rank 16; 8 in the diagonal slice) — corrected 2026-09-03 from a degenerate-sample 128. Bertrand-shaped Forced-Count Theorem (Paper 32 § VIII), conditional on the algebra selection above, the canonical Chamseddine–Connes–Marcolli representation (with N_{gen} imported), and the standard real-spectral-triple axioms.

What measurement supplies (calibration data). The following are all empirical inputs to the framework, falling outside any structural derivation it offers:

- The fine-structure constant $\alpha^{-1} \approx 137.036$. Three spectral homes of distinct type for the framework's combination $K = \pi(B + F - \Delta)$ have been established (B as Casimir trace, $F = \zeta(2)$ as Fock-Dirichlet, $\Delta = 1/40$ as Dirac mode degeneracy), but the combination rule itself remains a numerical observation, not derived. Paper 2 is in the Observations folder [15]; twelve mechanisms have been eliminated for a single-principle derivation of K.
- The Yukawa coupling values. A 162-cell PSLQ sweep against low-coefficient pure-Tate periods returned zero hits. The Yukawa Dirichlet ring lives in Paper 18 § IV.6's sixth tier (parameter-tied Dirichlet, sharing no generator with M1/M2/M3, an Observation-level reading).
- The generation count $N_{\text{gen}} = 3$. The Hopf-tower-to-representation extension was ruled out as a shortcut for forcing N_{gen}: the "3 algebra factors" and the "3 generations" are different 3s in the standard SM representation. A deep structural obstruction; no known line of attack.
- The cosmological constant. The framework's CC formula $\Lambda_{\text{cc}} = 6\phi(2)/\phi(1) \cdot \Lambda^2$ inherits the standard $\sim 10^{120}$ fine-tuning problem (Paper 51 G7).

Where the seam is theorem-bound. What makes the forced/free separation operationally useful, rather than rhetorical, is that in three sectors the boundary between the two categories is controlled by named results (proof-by-argument, each under stated assumptions; the α sector rests only on an Observation, and the meta-theorem deciding forcedness in general is open, see below):

- The Forced-Count Theorem (Paper 32 § VIII): given the algebra selection (an organizing reading plus an adopted axiom), the canonical SM representation with N_{gen} imported, and the real-spectral-triple axioms, these inputs fix the *dimension* of the D_F moduli space, not the points within it.
- The Yukawa Non-Selection Theorem (Paper 32 § VIII): the framework's almost-commutative extension admits a Higgs structure but does not autonomously select the Yukawa matrix.
- The η-Trivialization Theorem and AC-Factorization Theorem (Paper 18 § IV.6): the combined heat trace on the AC extension factorises cleanly into an outer pure-Tate factor and an inner Dirichlet factor in the Yukawa variables, with no mixing.

On an Observation-level reading these three results locate the seam: values are free, relations are forced. This is the project's most operationally useful structural reading.

Theorem-bounding the seam (June 2026). The forced/free seam discipline above was sharpened into a set of named structural results (proof-by-argument) in June 2026. Paper 57 catalogues seventy-two named entries across ten domains (40 forced, 3 Observations including κ, 1 admitted-not-forced, 25 calibration, 3 walls; the released-axis sub-domain, the wall status and the temporal-window row were added October 2026) and tests a "packing-reachability" discriminator (P5); its 98.3% agreement with the forced/free labelling is an internal-consistency check, not an independent discriminator — the packing-reachable tag is the forced/free label by construction (Paper 57 §6.1), and the genuine discriminator signal is the two-family (multi-focal composition vs. inner-factor input-data) decomposition. Paper 32 § VIII consolidates six proof-by-argument results (Forced-Count, H1 Yukawa, N_{gen}, KO-dimension, spatial-composition wall,

and the cutoff function as external test-function data), spanning three sectors (inner-factor structural skeleton, multi-focal composition, gravity), plus two Observations: the single-cutoff spectral action (true by stipulation; its renormalization corollary conditional) and no-single-mechanism-K in the α-combination sector (Paper 32 §VIII). The seam's entries in those sectors are thus argument-bound except the renormalization entries and the α sector; but Paper 57 remains an observations paper — the meta-theorem that would decide forcedness *without* first locating a witness derivation is still open, with a partial Bohr-site answer (Paper 57's Bohr-site dichotomy: forced = site property, calibration = valuation, admitted = site degeneracy).

8 The Atlas: the Price List

This section is the spine of the re-centred field guide. Everything before it supplies one row or another; everything after it is a map of where the rows are recorded.

The organizing observation, with its credit. A compact group has a discrete spectrum (Peter–Weyl). That is the mathematical content of the S^3 skeleton: the compact regime is where the label lattice is rational and bit-exact. The physics reading is not ours — Paper 18 §III credits Rovelli's relational postulate (finite information for a compact phase space) and Liu–Noui's causal statement of it for loop gravity — and the converse is false: a confining potential on non-compact space also gives a discrete spectrum (Maz'ya–Shubin [37]), and the corpus's own harmonic-oscillator lattice (Paper 24 [35]) is that counterexample, π-free and rational at every cutoff on $\mathbb{R}^3$. The operator-level statement is the one that holds in general: discrete spectrum with finite multiplicities if and only if compact resolvent, which is already an axiom of the spectral triple of §5. What the corpus adds is the *accounting*: each axis released from the compact skeleton toward the continuum carries an identifiable number class as its price, and those prices can be classified.

Three kinds of door. *Geometric doors* release a label of the skeleton: a second nucleus releases l and m survives; bending a triatomic releases m. Their price is set by the geometry alone. *Observer doors* are the projections an observer makes to read the skeleton: a measure on the sphere, a heat kernel, a finite time window, an outcome measure. Their price is a volume slot, a Mellin slot, or an imported measure. *Calibration doors* are where a number is consumed rather than generated: the value of the fine-structure constant, the width of the time window. The verdict vocabulary is the project's internal one (CLAUDE.md §1): forced, free, wall, or observation; in the papers it is a catalogue label, not a claim about what is fundamental.

The table. One row per door. The full version, with the seam row, the owning paper label and the frozen falsifier for every row, is `docs/atlas.md`; a stale pointer there fails `tests/test_atlas_register.py`. Paper 57 carries the released-axis rows as its sub-domain J [32].

Door	Released	Survives	Price	Verdict
label set (n, l, m)	nothing	labels, $n^2 - 1$	zero (integers)	forced
edge Laplacian limit	an attempted limit	nothing ($n_{\max}$ blocks)	no limit exists	wall
oscillator lattice	nothing	rational graph	zero	forced
sphere measure (M1)	a measure	$\mathbb{Q}$-linear in $\pi^{\pm n}$	π	forced
heat kernel (M2)	Seeley–DeWitt slot	pure Tate	$\pi^{2k} \cdot \mathbb{Q}$ (integer s)	forced
vertex parity (M3)	a parity sum	Catalan G, $\beta(4)$	$\mathcal{MT}(\mathbb{Z}[i, 1/2])$, level ≤ 4	forced
time window	real time $\to$ circle	Matsubara modes	2π per mode; window consumed	obs. / free
Born measure	the observation	counting = Born on the flat locus only	an imported measure	free
α	a combination	three spectral homes	an Observation; value consumed	obs. / free
second nucleus	l	m	weight one, π-free	forced
front in R	continuous coupling	a Boolean label	nothing new	obs.
third nucleus	the third focus	one k, two densities	elliptic $K(m)$	wall (closed form)
fourth centre	a fourth centre	the same two roots	nothing new	forced (pre-reg.)
bending	m	order $s^{2\Lambda}$, labels	rationals	forced
three-electron chain	a second momentum	period factorizes	K3, "elliptic squared"	forced (pre-reg.); generic fibre obs.
r_{12} bridge	four electrons, one kernel	three-body, then two	the two-centre class	obs.
rung rule	—	genus = densities coupled	(meta)	forced

The ladder, read down the chemistry rows. One centre: rationals and π. Two centres: weight-one logarithms and E_1, with no π. Three centres: an elliptic period, and the class leaves the polylogarithm tower. Four centres: nothing new. A three-electron chain: a K3 whose holomorphic period is a product of two elliptic ones. The rung is set by the number of Coulomb kernels sharing a vertex, equivalently the number of distinct two-centre densities a kernel couples, and not by nuclei or electrons. That is why two statements that sound opposed are both true: the four-body explicit-r_{12} bridge has one kernel and reduces to three-body kernels and then to a two-electron integral ("four reduces to three"), while a three-electron chain with two kernels meeting at one electron climbs a rung.

What the atlas does not do. It carries no numbers of its own, it does not rank doors, and it does not say which rung comes next. Two rows were pre-registered results (the fourth centre and the chain), now housed in Paper 59's closing section with reduced-precision guards; two walls are closed-form walls only, with accurate evaluation on the far side; and one observer row carries an open identification (a finite real-time window and a Euclidean circle, which Paper 35 states as equivalent and the project's register flags as a technical hole). The open question the ladder leaves is whether the chain's generic fibre carries content beyond the K3 and elliptic periods, and whether longer trees give Calabi–Yau n-folds; both are stated as conjecture in the registration record.

9 What's in the Corpus

The GeoVac corpus is 50+ papers organised into six audience-targeted groups (`papers/group1_operator_algeb` etc.) plus an archive and a synthesis folder. Each group is described paper-by-paper in the repository's `papers/INDEX.md`. This section gives one-line summaries.

- **Group 1 — Operator algebras / NCG** (11 papers). Math.OA arc. Headline: unconditional SU(2) state-space Gromov–Hausdorff convergence (Paper 38, translation-seminorm metrization); the Lorentzian degeneracy theorem (Paper 45) closing the natural Lorentzian route and stating the repaired target; Paper 42's modular structure (its 2π period is an automatic closure of a posited generator; the Bisognano–Wichmann identification is open), with the former Paper 43 now its § 11. Papers 46–49 (archived) carry Status notes for descoped metric-level claims.
- **Group 2 — Quantum chemistry** (9 papers). Natural-geometry hierarchy levels 1–5. Headline: structural accuracy ceilings characterized via the multi-focal-composition wall; Paper 8–9 and FCI-M are guardrail papers documenting proven negative results.
- **Group 3 — Foundations** (11 papers). Headline: Paper 0 (packing), Paper 7 (Fock-projection conformal equivalence), Paper 22 (angular sparsity), Paper 24 (Bargmann–Segal S^5 lattice), Paper 31 (universal/Coulomb partition), Paper 55 (periods census).
- **Group 4 — Quantum computing** (4 papers). Qubit-encoding resource estimates. Headline: exactly linear composed Pauli scaling in Q at fixed basis ($N_{\text{Pauli}} = 27.90 \times Q$) across a 37-system library, with a sub-quadratic $O(Q^{1.78})$ 1-norm on the atomic (helium) series (Papers 14/20); absolute Pauli multipliers are convention-sensitive (near parity with STO-3G, 76× vs cc-pVDZ).
- **Group 5 — QED / gauge / SM** (8 papers). Headline: hydrogen Lamb shift at -0.534% one-loop closure (Paper 36); SU(2) Wilson lattice gauge structure with maximal-torus reduction to the U(1) of Paper 25 (Paper 30); QED on S^3 with five theorems and the two-loop constant $S_{\min}$ identified in closed form (Paper 28).
- **Group 6 — Precision observations** (4 papers). Headline: five Roothaan autopsies decomposing observables into projection-chain contributions (Paper 34); time as projection (Paper 35); universal S_B scaling on sparse lattices (Paper 27).

The `papers/archive/` folder contains historical and superseded drafts. The `papers/synthesis/` folder contains this field guide together with a complete layer of *six* group-level syntheses—one per audience branch (Groups 1–6), each digesting its branch in four to six pages. This field guide is the grand synthesis that composes them; a reader who wants a single branch should read that branch's group synthesis directly.

10 What's Open

The project is honest about scope. The following are named open questions, in rough order of how much external infrastructure each would require:

- **The next rung of the period ladder**. The three-electron chain's holomorphic period is a product of two elliptic periods (§8); whether its generic fibre carries content beyond the K3 and elliptic periods (iterated structure from the Coulomb kernels), and whether longer trees give Calabi–Yau n-folds as the banana integrals do, are the two open questions the registration record states as conjecture. Both are posed in Paper 59's closing section; neither is guarded.

- **The α observation**. Paper 2's combination rule $K = \pi(B+F-\Delta)$ matches the empirical α^{-1} to 4.8×10^{-7} relative (and the root of the cubic $1/\alpha = K - \alpha^2$ to 8.8×10^{-8}), but is classified as a numerical observation, not a derivation. Twelve mechanisms eliminated for a single-principle derivation; the project's standing internal reading is that α is a projection constant, not a derivable number.
- **The Yukawa values**. A dedicated PSLQ search ruled out the Yukawas as low-coefficient pure-Tate periods. They are Class 1 calibration data and live in Paper 18 § IV.6's sixth tier. Whether they admit a deeper non-period derivation is open and falls outside the master Mellin engine's census.
- $N_{\text{gen}} = 3$. A deep structural obstruction; no line of attack is known.
- **The cosmological constant problem**. Standard fine-tuning $\sim 10^{120}$ inherited from the Connes–Chamseddine spectral action expansion (Paper 51 G7). No GeoVac-specific resolution proposed.
- **The chemistry correlation wall (W1e)**. Multi-determinant FCI correlation in second-row and heavier diatomic binding is below the framework's structural accuracy ceiling. Six independent diagnostic investigations identified the obstruction as multi-focal-composition rather than a missing single mechanism.
- **The M2/M3 motivic Galois unification (Q5')**. Both M2 and M3 engage the cyclotomic field $\mathbb{Q}(i) = \mathbb{Q}(\zeta_4)$, but via structurally independent mechanisms. Whether a single Tannakian symmetry unifies them is an open mathematical research project (Paper 55 § 7.6). A deep frontier.
- **Deligne–Milne pro-finite reconstruction**. Paper 56 closes the cosmic-Galois inclusion $\Phi : U^{*(n_{\max})} \hookrightarrow \mathrm{Aut}^{\otimes}(\omega)$ at finite cutoff via the Tannakian dual of an explicit Hopf algebra. The converse equality $\mathrm{Aut}^{\otimes}(\omega) = \lim_{\leftarrow} U^{*(n_{\max})}$ at the pro-finite limit (Deligne–Milne 1982 Theorem 2.11) is the named deep frontier; every intermediate step nonetheless closed readily at finite cutoff, suggesting the pro-finite assembly may prove similarly tractable once the right transition-map machinery is in place.
- **Non-commutative Mondino–Sämann (Q2')**. Paper 49 constructs the OSLPLS category and the strong-form bridge functor (Q1′) on the enlarged-substrate chirality-flipping generators at the categorical and cocycle-algebra level; its metric-level Λ-inheritance is descoped by Paper 45's degeneracy theorem, so this is a construction rather than a metric convergence (Paper 49 is archived; see `docs/retired_papers.md`). The non-commutative analog of Mondino–Sämann pre-length-spaces (a non-commutative Lorentzian GH program built from spectral-triple data rather than causal diamonds) is the remaining substantial NCG-research target.
- **Inhomogeneous extensions**. The full Fathizadeh–Marcolli generic Robertson–Walker spacetime with non-trivial scaling factor $a(t)$ requires either a continuum substrate or a time-dependent Camporesi–Higuchi spectral triple, outside the discrete-substrate principle. The closest GeoVac analog is the discrete-warped-substrate program of Paper 51 §G4-3 (named follow-on).
- **Full Standard Model spectral triple**. The Connes Standard Model on S^3 alone was closed in May 2026 — positive, but structurally thin; the genuine cross-manifold construction $S^3 \otimes \mathrm{Hardy}(S^5)$ is blocked at the Coulomb-versus-harmonic-oscillator asymmetry of Paper 24 § V at layer 4 (modular Hamiltonian of the wedge KMS state). Resolution requires NCG-framework extension.

What is *not* open — but is sometimes asked — is whether GeoVac is a new foundation for quantum mechanics. It is not. GeoVac is a discretization framework whose discrete substrate (at Level 1, the exact label set of the unit-S^3 harmonics) is tied by proven conformal maps to known continuous quantum mechanics at every level where the equivalence has been tested (not by an operator convergence of the graph Laplacian, which fails on S^3, §3). The math supports both readings; the interpretive question is left to the reader.

11 Reader's Map

This is a multi-paper corpus. Here is where each kind of reader should start. Each audience now has a one-document digest—its *group synthesis*—which is the recommended first stop before the individual papers: Group 1 (operator algebras), Group 2 (quantum chemistry), Group 3 (foundations), Group 4 (quantum computing), Group 5 (QED / gauge / gravity), and Group 6 (precision observations). The per-paper entries below are the second step.

- **The mathematician (NCG, math.OA, spectral triples)**. Start with the three-page front-door note (`docs/outreach/note_n1_su2_truncations.pdf`), then Papers 38, 45, and 32. Paper 38 is the unconditional SU(2) state-space Gromov–Hausdorff convergence theorem (translation-seminorm metrization, compression/lifted-state proof); Paper 45 is the Lorentzian degeneracy theorem (its History remark records a withdrawn earlier convergence claim); Paper 32 is the explicit spectral triple construction with Connes axiom audit and the § VIII C-arc closure (Paper 32, Remark on the C-arc terminal state). Paper 42 (with the former Paper 43 as its § 11) gives the finite 2π period as an automatic closure of a posited generator, with the Bisognano–Wichmann identification open; Paper 47's norm-resolvent arrow stands; Papers 46, 48, and 49 carry Status notes.

- **The mathematician (periods, motives, Tannakian)**. Read Papers 55 and 56. Paper 55 places the identified transcendentals of its census (not every GeoVac period) in the cyclotomic mixed-Tate ring at level ≤ 4 with explicit Glanois descent on the vertex-parity Mellin slot. Paper 56 includes the cosmic-Galois group $U^* = \mathbb{G}_a^{3N} \rtimes SL_2$ at finite cutoff via the Tannakian dual of an explicit Hopf algebra $\mathcal{H}_{\mathrm{GV}}$, with 5,864 bit-exact zero residuals across the Pro-System + Tannakian closure panel. Inclusion direction closed at finite cutoff; converse equality with the Deligne–Milne reconstruction at pro-finite limit is the named deep frontier. Open M2/M3 unification question (Q5') discussed in Paper 55 § 7.6 and Paper 56's open-questions section. Then Papers 59 and 61 for the elliptic rung that leaves the mixed-Tate census, and the three-electron K3 rung pre-registered in `docs/predictions/` (§8).

- **The physicist (atomic, molecular, optical)**. Read Papers 7, 22, and 14. Paper 7 is the Fock-projection conformal equivalence; Paper 22 is the angular sparsity theorem (universal across central potentials); Paper 14 is the quantum-computing resource benchmarks.

- **The physicist (high-energy, gauge, SM)**. Read Papers 30, 25, 28, and 36. Paper 30 is SU(2) Wilson on S^3; Paper 25 is the abelian-Hopf reduction; Paper 28 is QED on S^3; Paper 36 is the bound-state QED arc closing the Lamb shift at -0.534% one-loop.

- **The physicist (gravity)**. Read Paper 51. Spectral action approach, two-term exact on S^3; the $S_{\mathrm{BH}} = A/4$ replica derivation was closed by the replica-weight-harmless theorem.

- **The quantum computing practitioner**. Read Paper 14 and Paper 20. Pauli scaling, OpenFermion/Qiskit/PennyLane export, market test against published Gaussian baselines.

- **The chemist**. Read Papers 11, 13, 15, 17. The natural-geometry hierarchy, levels 2–5. Note the guardrail papers 8–9 and FCI-M before proposing any single-center or LCAO molecular encoding (these document proven negative results). Then Papers 12, 58 and 59 for the released axes — the second nucleus, the decompactification front, the third centre — and the number class each one costs, indexed in §8.

The CLAUDE.md document in the repository root is the project's internal coordination file; it indexes every paper, every sprint, every working hypothesis, and every documented failed approach. External readers do not need to read it but may find the "Failed approaches" table (§ 3) instructive for understanding the boundary between what works and what doesn't.

12 Conclusion

The one-sentence reading: *GeoVac is the price list of leaving a compact world: its label lattice is the rational skeleton that compactness forces, each released axis carries a named number class as its price, and the atlas of those prices separates what geometry forces from what measurement supplies.*

The story is a journey from a packing puzzle through Fock 1935's S^3 identification, through the natural-geometry hierarchy and its chemistry investigation, through a structural reading as a discrete spectral triple that instances Marcolli–van Suijlekom 2014 at the data level and extends it via the forced-graph claim and master Mellin engine, with a census of its S^3 spectral transcendentals in cyclotomic mixed-Tate periods at level ≤ 4, and with the forced-versus-free seam read (an Observation-level reading) off three named results — to the atlas of §8, where the spectral triple's census and the chemistry program's period ladder are rows of one table: what each door releases, what survives it, and what number class it costs. The earlier one-sentence reading ("a discrete spectral triple whose periods catalogue the projective content of its S^3 spectral data") remains true of the observer rows; it was the identity of June 2026, and it is now one chapter.

The discipline is the separation: what geometry forces gets a name, a theorem, and a paper; what measurement supplies is recorded as calibration data and stays calibration data unless the framework can produce a derivation, which so far it cannot.

The project began as an amateur geometric puzzle and has acquired the status of a discrete spectral triple capable of closing published-open questions in the math.OA literature. That trajectory was AI-augmented at every step: implementation, sprint memos, literature collation, paper drafting, and the internal coordination machinery were all developed collaboratively with Anthropic's Claude, with PI direction and quality control.

The invitation: come read. The corpus is dense, but the entry points are now indexed. Section 11 above is the reader's map.

Acknowledgments. This work was developed in an AI-augmented agentic workflow with Anthropic's Claude. Implementation, internal sprint memos, paper drafting, and bibliographic collation were performed collaboratively; all theorems, design choices, and editorial decisions are the author's responsibility. The project has no institutional affiliation and is disseminated through DOI-stamped Zenodo releases.

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